



Station to Station: Kazuo Ishiguro's Top Ten Train Films

Tickets

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Directors: Ermanno Olmi, Abbas Kiarostami, Ken Loach
Production Companies: Fandango Produzione Cinematografica, Sixteen Films
In association with: UK Film Council
With the Support of: Invicta Capital
In Collaboration with: Medusa, Sky Italia
Supported by:
The National Lottery through UK Film Council, UK Film Council New Cinema Fund
Producers: Carlo Cresto-Dina, Babak Karimi, Rebecca O'Brien, Domenico Procacci
Line Producer: Valeria Licurgo
Supervising Production Accountant: Claudio Zampetti
Production Accountants: Laura Cimarelli, Habib Rahman
Production Co-ordinators: Raffaella Di Giulio, Camilla Bray
Production Managers: Gian Luca Chiaretti, Roberta Licurgo
Unit Managers: Maria Continella, Alessandro Sogliuzzo
Post-production Supervisor: Shuna Frood
Production Assistants: Umberto Incerti, Marcello Amore, Gaia Russo Frattasi, Layla Mall, Alfredo Mauro, Gianfranco Strazza
Assistant Directors: Gaia Gorini, Babak Karimi, Duccio Fabbri, Giuseppe Ferlito, Filippo Metz
Script Supervisors: Fiorella Lugli, Giorgia Onofri
Casting: Laura Muccino, Anna Maria Sambucco, Genti Minga
Screenplay: Ermanno Olmi, Abbas Kiarostami, Paul Laverty
Photography: Fabio Olmi, Mahmoud Kalari, Chris Menges
Focus Pullers: Francesca D'Antoni, Silvia Falanga, Massimiliano Pantucci
Key Grips: Roberto Pecci, Giuseppe Riccardi
Grips: Francesco Caffa
Gaffers: Stefano Marino, Fabio Proserpio
Electricians: Giuseppe Meloni, Leonardo Beltrame, Elvis Musicco
Stills Photography: Chico de Luigi
Editors: Giovanni Ziberna, Babak Karimi, Jonathan Morris
Assistant Editors: Federica Ravera, Francesco Loffredo, Anthony Morris
Production Designer: Alessandro Vannucci
Art Director: Marta Maffucci
Properties: Carlo Pagani, Massimo Ticciati, Lee Porter
Costume Designer: Maurizio Basile
Wardrobe: Gianni Addante, Carole K. Millar
Wardrobe Mistresses: Anna Sciotti, Roberta Mangano
Make-up: Fernanda Perez, Susanna Gastaldi
Hair: Adriana La Macchia, Mary Mancuso
Titles: Cineimage
Titles Design: M. Butterworth, Creative Partnership
Laboratories: Technicolor (Rome), Technicolor London, Colour Film Services
Music: George Fenton
Music Engineer: Keith Grant
Sound Recordists: Francesco Liotard, Maricetta Lombardo, Ray Beckett
Boom Operators: Stefano Slocovitch, Luca Novelli, Chiara Bersani
Sound Re-recording: John Hayward, Richard Pryke
DPS: Paolo Frati
Sound Editors: Kevin Brazier, Daniela Bassani
Sound Effects Editor: Robert Brazier

Three Palme d'Or winners share the directing credit, but I've yet to find anyone who has seen this film. (Aside from the stranger in the Japanese restaurant who alerted me to its existence – my thanks to him.) This triptych film moves through a single pool of passengers on a crowded European train; among them an ageing professor, some boisterous Glasgow Rangers fans and a refugee family. If the three directors' styles mix too unevenly to make this a lost classic, *Tickets* is nevertheless extraordinarily fascinating. And Kiarostami's episode is a particular revelation.

Kazuo Ishiguro

A contemporary review

The idea for *Tickets* originated in an informal conversation between producers Carlo Cresto-Dina and Babak Karimi. But it wasn't until Abbas Kiarostami met his chosen collaborators Ken Loach and Ermanno Olmi that the film's form and narrative premise fell into place. Though it's tempting to see Loach and Olmi's contributions as mere wings to the triptych's central piece (indeed, one famous critic ostentatiously left the screening I attended the minute Kiarostami's section finished), it was Olmi who came up with the conceit of the train journey, and it's his lustrous and extraordinarily textured first section that opens the film.

Carlo Delle Piane, a regular in the films of Olmi's compatriot Pupi Avati, plays an elderly pharmacist (anonymously dubbed 'the professor') experiencing travel chaos in Austria. He's been away on business but is expected back home in Rome for the birthday party of his grandson. His scheduled flight has run into problems, but Valéria Bruni Tedeschi's angel of an Austrian PA (she has golden hair and appears almost to be floating) has found him a ticket for an intercity train. He's impressed that she has booked him for two meal sittings in the dining car so he will be assured a seat for the duration of the journey. Yet some kind of security crisis seems to be affecting the train. In a scene chillingly reminiscent of countless World War II-set scenarios, before the journey begins soldiers and police patrol the station concourse as Tannoys bark German and German Shepherd dogs nose around. The passengers look confused, intimidated and a little frightened. There's a scent of madness in the air.

Delle Piane's character bears precious little resemblance to that other Italian chemist, Primo Levi. With his fashionable flat cap, neat white beard, rimless spectacles and indignation at being asked for identity papers by a passing policeman, there's something absurd about him. And there's a whisper of Visconti's late movies about ageing and memory in the way he descends into reveries about ethereal blondes. As Chopin is played in the carriage (a fellow passenger cannot get his CD player earpiece to operate) the professor tries to write a letter of thanks to Bruni Tedeschi's PA, which elides, via memories of childhood experiences of music, into fantastical confessions of romantic attraction. The more he dreams of girls playing pianos and candlelit dinners with his angel, the more he is given to little whimsical skips and euphoric gambols. His dainty rejection and then acceptance of an aperitif is in some sense the 'strawberry moment' of *Death in Venice*. The professor confesses in voiceover, to be 'daydreaming like a teenager'. Yet here is a man facing old age who cannot even decide on the way to address his correspondent, relentlessly writing and rewriting his opening sentence.

What's especially noticeable about this first section is how Olmi uses sound – the boom of station noise, overheard music and conversations, babies squalling in corridors, the sometimes deafening rattle of the train fading in and

Foley Artists: John Fewell, Julie Ankerson
 Foley Re-recording Mixer: Ben Brazier
 Assistant to Mr Olmi: Federica Ravera
 Publicity: Daniel Staffa, Marinella Di Rosa
 Cast:
 Carlo Delle Piane (*professor*)
 Valiria Bruni Tedeschi (*PR lady*)
 Silvana De Santis (*Italian lady*)
 Filippo Trojano (*Filippo*)
 Martin Compston (*Jamesy*)
 William Ruane (*Frank*)
 Gary Maitland (*Spaceman*)
 Blerta Cahani (*Albanian family: girl*)
 Klajdi Qorraj (*Albanian family: boy*)
 Aishe Gjuriqi (*Albanian family: mother*)
 Sanije Dedja (*Albanian family: grandmother*)
 Kled Salaj (*Albanian family: baby*)
 Edmond Budina (*Albanian family: father*)
 Danilo Nigrelli (*man with mobile*)
 Carolina Benvenega (*girl*)
 Marta Mangiucco (*other girl*)
 Irene Bufo (*woman in red*)
 Roberto Nobile, Mauro Pirovano (*ticket collectors*)
 Eugenia Costantini, Chiara Gensini,
 Maria De Los Angeles Parrinello, Viviana Strambelli
 (*Italian travelling girls*)
 Italy-UK 2005
 110 mins
 35mm

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out of muffled private moments – to get around the restrictions of space
 imposed by the train location. But try as he might, the professor can't help but
 be drawn back to the reality of the carriage's night-mirrored window and the
 army officer (who looks oddly like Jean-Claude Van Damme, but isn't) sitting
 scowling opposite him. The soldier speaks only accented English – the new
 voice of international imperialism, we must understand – but his greatest crime
 is causing a mother to spill her baby's milk as she hunkers down to feed the
 child in the crowded corridor between carriages. As the professor asks the
 waiter to bring him some warm milk so he can take it to the mother, and the
 train staff mop up the spillage, which looks so much like a puddle of blood, the
 moment of final resignation comes: the sleep of old age and the old grown
 helpless like babies again.

From St. Jerome to the rampaging rhinocerine Madonna of Kiarostami's central
 section, which is shot in daylight. A woman in late middle-age, with white hair
 and a string of pearls, boards the train with a host of suitcases gamely carried
 by a young assistant. She treats him as a lover, a toyboy, a kept man; but it
 later transpires that he appears to be on some form of national service, and
 that she is a widow on the way to a memorial service for her army-general
 husband. Silvana De Santis plays the woman with sweaty, angry energy;
 nothing will stand in her way and she will co-operate with no one she considers
 beneath her. The young man, played by Filippo Trojano, has a sad expression
 and beautiful eyes, which are later accentuated by the flat lighting Kiarostami
 deploys when the man is talking to a young friend of his sister whom he meets
 in the corridor (and of whom De Santis' character is jealous). This frontality, this
 sense of painted iconography, is homage enough to Kiarostami's late friend
 Pier Paolo Pasolini (Kiarostami's charcoal sketch of Pasolini hung in the
 bedroom of the Rome flat of the Italian director's muse, Laura Betti, until her
 death last year).

By the conclusion of this second segment De Santis and Trojano's characters
 have rowed and separated. She leaves the train alone and unaided, but not
 before one of the best sequences in the film, which harks back to one of the
 Iranian director's longstanding obsessions and involves an argument over
 mobile phones (Kiarostami considers them a curse of modernity). The
 performances in this section are generally the best in the movie, and the final
 bust-up between Kiarostami's characters, shot through Venetian blinds with the
 reflection of the countryside rushing past, is quite beautiful.

And so to Ken Loach. His section does little with the space or the noise of the
 environment, and concentrates squarely on character – with a touch of
 comedy thrown in. His protagonists are fans of Celtic FC: three of them, all
 young men, travelling to Rome, like Chaucerian pilgrims, for a Champions
 League match. They've brought a huge bag of sandwiches from their Asda
 workplace to feed themselves along the way. After one of them gives a
 sandwich to a young Albanian boy they discover the lad has stolen a train
 ticket from them. There is then a moral struggle as the Scots talk to the family
 of the boy and have to make a quick decision about letting them keep the
 ticket. Is the family genuinely in need, or are they crooks? With Loach we
 always know the wisdom of the working man will shine through, and so it does.
 The Celtic fans make the right call, and the fraternity of football fandom
 gathered at the station in Rome helps the seemingly fare-dodging trio to evade
 the police. If Loach delivers easily the least rich and imaginative section of the
 film, it's a satisfyingly light conclusion to Olmi's frightening opening gambit and
 a welcome return to normality.

Roger Clarke, *Sight and Sound*, December 2005